



you more than 200 minutes of battery life (maybe even 4hrs or more if you're careful) and has a decent keyboard and a nice touchpad. All this at a price that's half that of the competition. Not bad, eh?

If you really are on a tight budget and need a laptop for working on (browsing and typing only mind you), the V5-123 might just be the one for you.

Editor's Pick Dell Inspiron 11 3000 series

While this laptop didn't win any performance crowns in the comparison, it was still easily one of our favourite laptops that we tested. The device itself is tiny, given the 11.6 inch screen that it has, and as you can see from the table, it doesn't seem well-endowed in the performance department.

However, the performance on offer is just sufficient to keep the device ticking. There is some amount of lag but it's only noticeable under medium-high loads, where you've got a dozen or so Chrome tabs open or are trying to play a really high-quality HD video file. Windows 8.1 itself is very smooth and the touchscreen is very responsive.

The device is well-built and in terms of design, this was one of our favourites; the matte grey lid with the black Dell logo look really cool. The screen is thicker than we expected, almost as thick as the body in fact, but we suppose that's a side-effect of incorporating a touchscreen.

What impressed us the most was the incredible battery life of over 5.5 hrs, quite a feat in this segment and especially considering that our tests are quite strenuous, you should be able to extract anywhere

HOW WE TESTED

Testing laptops is no dark art, our test processes are quite thorough, but also simple enough to be performed by anyone at home, with the right tools and disposition.

Initial preparation

For every laptop we receive, we first log features, including making notes of bloatware, if present. The laptops are then completely formatted, all recovery partitions wiped and a fresh copy of Windows 8.1 Enterprise Edition (x64) is installed. Windows update is allowed to run and any remaining drivers are manually installed. The batteries are allowed to charge fully, any power saving options are disabled and the High Performance power plan is applied. All test suites and benchmarking programs, along with any essential programs, are installed on all laptops. All laptop screens are calibrated using the Spyder 3 Elite calibration tool.

1) Performance Tests

Performance tests consist of a whole suite of tests that give us an idea as to the laptop's capabilities under stress. The following tests are conducted:

PCMark 8: This suite is one of the best tools for acquiring a complete

picture of any PS's performance. We consider scores for the Home and Creative test suites.

3DMark: This tool is used to measure the raw performance capabilities of the laptop. The three tests that comprise the results fully stress the CPU and GPU like no other.

Cinebench R11.5: This tool is the ideal tool to indicate raw CPU performance. It renders a test scene using all CPU cores to give a result.

Battery life: PCMark 8's in-built battery test suite is used to estimate battery life. The test runs through a gamut of functions that are expected of a home PC, including browsing, chatting, video calls, light gaming, etc.

Sound quality: This is a subjective test where our reviewers rank each laptop's audio at 100 per cent and at 50 per cent volume.

Screen quality: The quality of the display is measured via the Spyder 3 Elite (calibration, brightness and contrast ratio), a physical device attached to screens. Lagom.nl is also used to measure black levels and various other factors including sharpness and white levels.

2) Features tests

All laptop features are listed out and assigned appropriate weights to come up with a final score. This includes the laptop configuration, connectivity options, weight, screen resolution and more.

3) Design and usability

These tests are mostly subjective and are an indicator of a laptop's ergonomics. Points are given for keyboard layout, touchpad functionality, quality of the construction materials, layout of ports (USB, HDMI, etc.) and presence of useful software.

4) Final Score

The Performance, Features and Design scores are assigned appropriate weights to derive a final score for all the products. The best performer award goes to the laptop with the highest performance score, regardless of price. The best buy award goes to the laptop with the best price to performance ratio based on a formula that we use.

What formula? If we tell you we'll have to kill you? Not really. Nothing that cliched. Just write in to us at testcentre@thinkdigit.com with any queries regarding our test process and we'll gladly help you out if we can.

between 6-8 hrs of usage from the 4-cell battery. Another thing that stood out was the incredibly low temperature under load (52 degrees celsius) though admittedly, the CPU isn't capable of crunching too many numbers in the first place. Not bad at all.

The only disappointment with this laptop has to be the screen itself. It's nice and sharp, but the backlight is a bit dim and viewing angles are not as

good as some of the others we've tested. Also, the touchpad can be a bit hyper-sensitive, but it's nothing you can't get used to.

This Dell Inspiron laptop wins the Editor's pick award for its great design and excellent portability, given the great battery life and low operating temperature it offers.

And that pretty much brings us to the end of this insightful comparison. We were pleasantly surprised at the variety

of devices that fell into our budget laptop category, and their improved overall quality from just a few years ago. We did receive many more laptops, including some from ASUS, but owing to issues while prepping them, we've been unable to feature them in our tests this time.

Be sure to keep an eye on <http://www.thinkdigit.com> for more in-depth reviews of these laptops, and others that weren't featured here. 